information officer, H.Y. Sharda Prasad, and hand over the note to him. Until then I had thought that the note was actually meant for the principal secretary to the PM and that the government would finally do something to improve the situation on the ground, both in Punjab and in the US and Canada.

As desired by Kao, I called on Sharda Prasad at his office on the first floor of South Block, to the left of the corridor opposite the PM's office. He went through the note carefully but did not discuss its contents with me. All he said was, 'Hmmm...' and then, 'You can go'. Managing the press and the media to project the right image of the PM and the government was his main job. In view of that, I thought he might brief the Indian press in his own way, to exercise restraint and help restore normalcy in relations between Hindus and Sikhs in Punjab and those settled abroad.

Unfortunately, that proved to be wishful thinking on my part. Gradually, the Indian media became even more virulent in their coverage of the communal divide in Punjab. The activities of Bhindranwale and Sikh extremists started getting greater prominence and front-page coverage even in the popular national newspapers. A well-known editor of a major newspaper started writing lead articles on the editorial page blaming the Sikhs for nursing ambitions of re-establishing the 'Khalsa Raj'.